



SANJAY RAMACHANDRAN

Art Under ATTACK

The controversial start of the NGMA's Bangalore centre highlights the growing disconnect between the institution and the art community

| By Nirmala Ravindran |

Most artists just sigh when they hear the magic letters—NGMA (National Gallery of Modern Art). The love-hate relationship between the community and the institution remains unchanged even after 54 years. That the NGMA has added additional exhibition space at Jaipur House in Delhi, taking the display area to 12,000 sq m at the cost of Rs 65 crore, or that an eight-year-long wait has come to an end with the inauguration of the southern centre, built at a cost of Rs 15 crore, seems to make no difference to the community. Take the delay in the inauguration of the south-

ern chapter due to funds being held up by the Ministry of Culture. The beautiful 100-year-old Manikyavelu Mansion, restructured by Bangalore-based architect Naresh Venkataraman, had more police officers inside than visitors even a week after it opened. Two weeks later nothing has changed. There is not a single person on the campus to answer questions or even direct an art lover who might wander into the campus. There are locked auditoriums at both the Mumbai and Bangalore centres but their purpose is still not known. A café and a museum shop are to open shortly. When is anybody's guess.

The inauspicious start saw a local boycott and a silent protest led by



THE SWANKY INTERIORS OF THE NGMA, BANGALORE (TOP); AN ARTEFACT ON DISPLAY